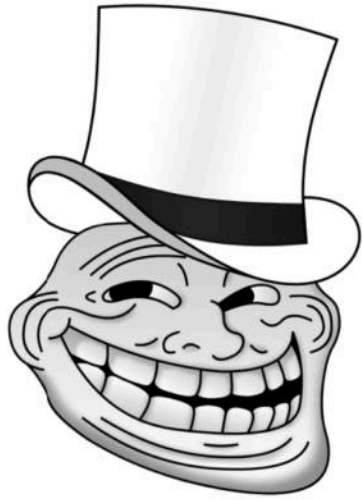
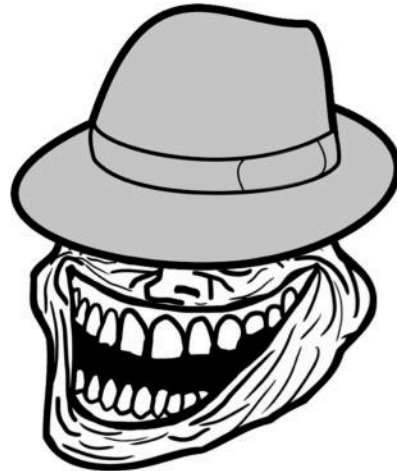




Beyond the Lulz:

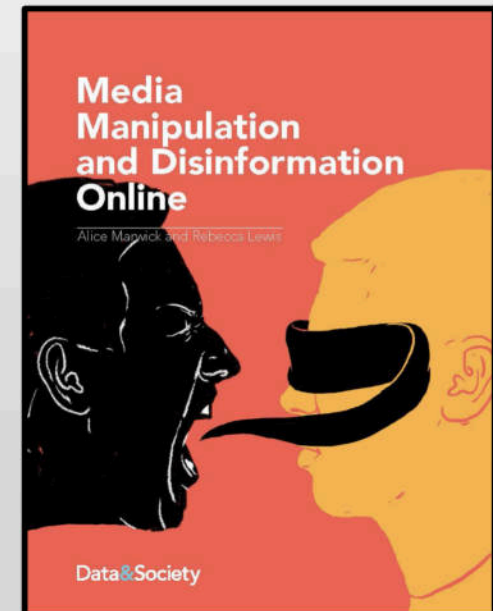
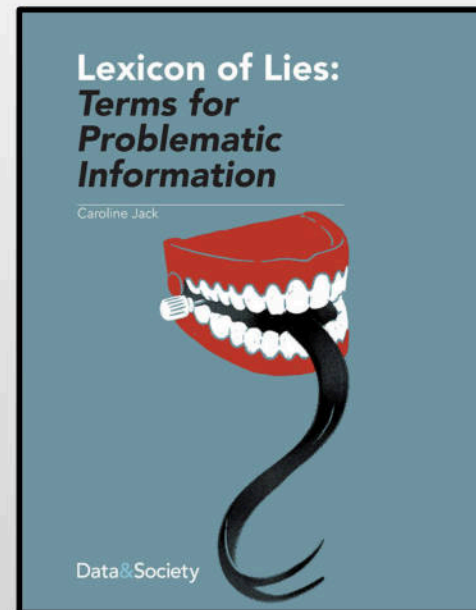
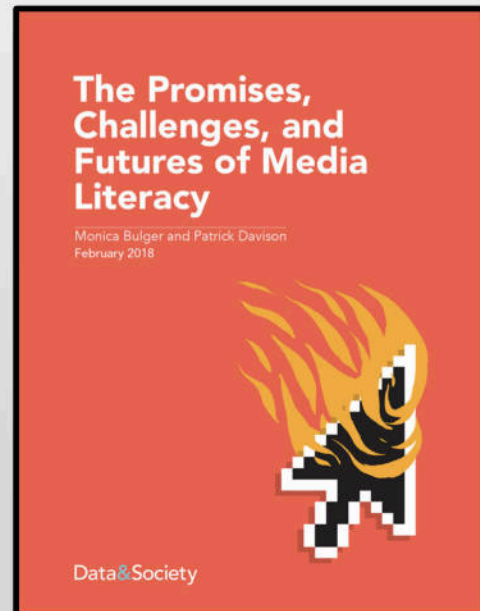
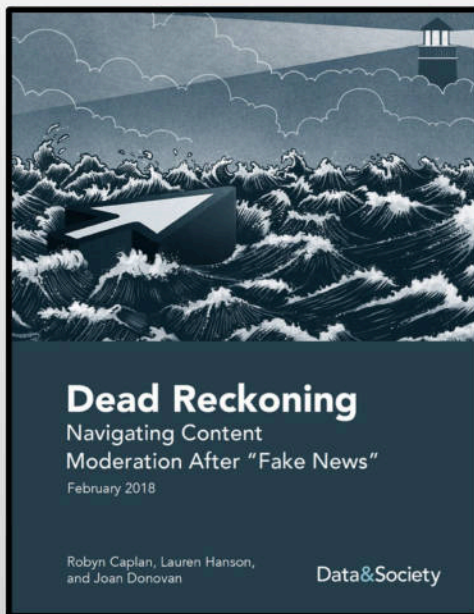


Black Hat Trolling, White Hat Trolling, and Hacking the Attention Landscape

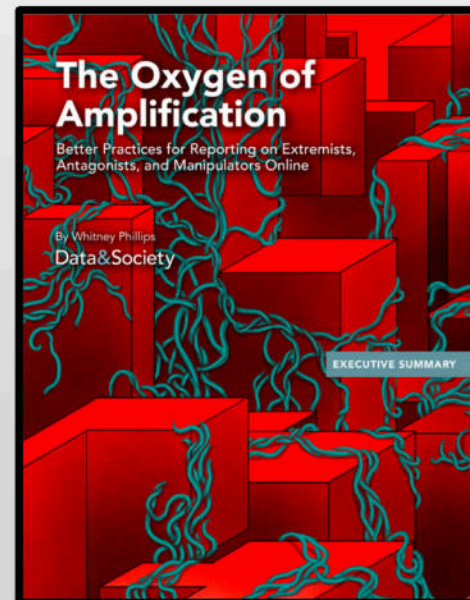




CONTEXT



CONTEXT



SECTION 1



HACKING and TROLLING

Trolling, as tricksterism



Are you familiar with fishing? Trolling is where you set your fishing lines in the water and then slowly go back and forth dragging the bait and hoping for a bite. Trolling on the Net is the same concept - someone baits a post and then waits for the bite on the line and then enjoys the ensuing fight.

- Anonymous usenet poster, 1995 (relayed by Judith Donath, *Identity and Deception in the Virtual Community*, 1998)

Trolling, as governance



The well-constructed troll is a post that induces lots of newbies and flammers to make themselves look even more clueless than they already do, while subtly conveying to the more savvy and experienced that it is in fact a deliberate troll. If you don't fall for the joke, you get to be in on it.

- Troller's FAQ by trollfaq@altairiv.demon.co.uk, 1996

Trolling, as abuse



Being a prick on the internet because you can. Typically unleashing one or more cynical or sarcastic remarks on an innocent by-stander, because it's the internet and, hey, you can.

- EREALLY GUD DEFUNITION MAKUR, Urban Dictionary, 2004

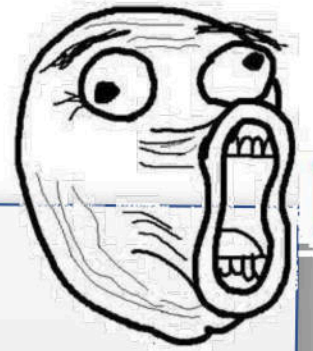
Trolling, as security economics?



A smart vendor treats vulnerabilities less as a software problem, and more as a PR problem. So if we, the user community, want software vendors to patch vulnerabilities, we need to make the PR problem more acute.

- Bruce Schneier, 2007

Trolling, as lulz



LOL

Laughter at the expense or misfortune of others.

- A troll to Gabriella Coleman,
Hacker, Hoaxer, Whistleblower, Spy, 2014

Trolling, as transgression



Part of:

*a rich aesthetic tradition of spectacle and transgression...
which includes the irreverent legacy of phreakers and the
hacker underground.*

- Gabriella Coleman, *Phreaks, Hackers, and Trolls: The Politics of Transgression and Spectacle*, 2012

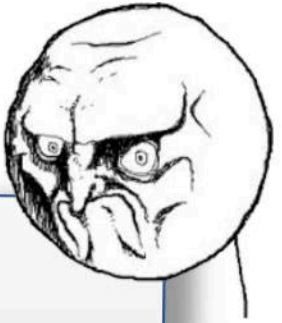
Trolling, as art



The best challenge to the authority of something is to find where its semantic or enforceable borders break down and to exploit those shortcomings.

- Brad Troemel, proclaimed the “Troll of Internet Art,” 2012

Trolling, as hate



We've come up with the menacing term 'troll' for someone who spreads hate and does other horrible things anonymously on the internet.

- Adrian Chen, *MIT Technology Review*, 2014

Trolling, as tacit media critique



Until sensationalist, exploitative media practices are no longer rewarded with page views and ad revenue—in short, until the mainstream is willing to step in front of the funhouse mirror and consider the contours of its own distorted reflection—the most aggressive forms of trolling will always have an outlet, and an audience.

- Whitney Phillips, *This Is Why We Can't Have Nice Things*, 2015

Trolling, who?



- Users looking to govern or police their communities
- Hackers looking to corral attention or pressure vendors
- Subcultural trolls looking for 'lulz'
- Artists looking to critique cultural practices
- Political actors looking to destabilize public sphere
- Political actors looking to corral attention or attack opponents

Trolling, components

- Troll
- Bait
- Target
- Third-party to interpret the exchange
- Intended outcome
 - (Possible amplification)
 - (Possible political reframing and subsequent amplification)

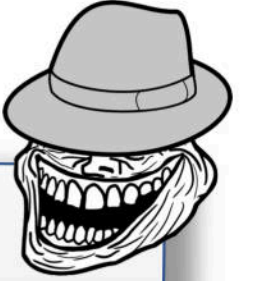


Trolling, what now?



- “Cognitive Hacking”? (Cybenko, et al)
- “Attention Hacking”? (boyd)
- “Cognitive Denial of Service”? (Waltzman)
- Exploiting Socio-Technical “Vulnerabilities”?
- A bug or a feature?

Trolling, how?



- Poe's Law
- Context Collapse
- Network Anonymity and Ephemerality
- Cross Platform Ambiguity
- Attention Economics (high cost of verification)
- Lack of Trust

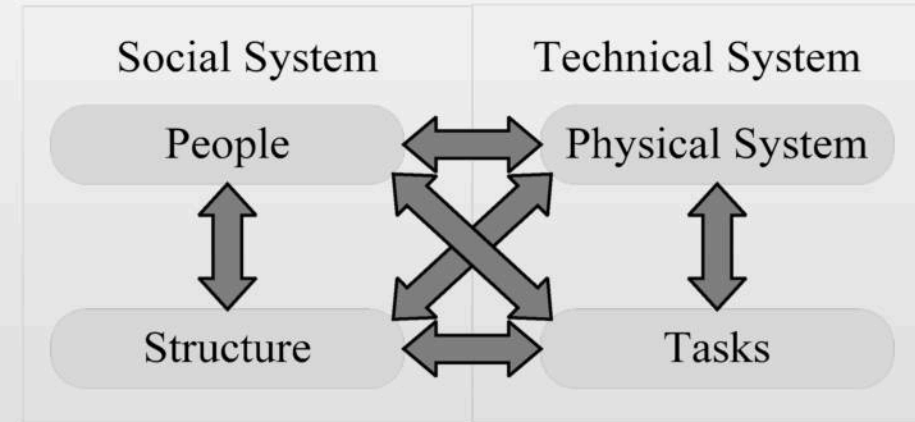
Political Possibilities



- **Draw** attention to ignored issues (agenda setting)
- **Distract** attention from issues
- Put **pressure** on entity (security economics) (accountability)
- Draw a telling **response** (transparency)
- **Deny** a response
- **Diminish** an opponent's resources or morale

Trolling as Socio-Technical Hacking

- Design ?vulnerabilities?
- Intent (public good) vs. Reality (profit)
- “Latent affordances”
- Trolling is to socio-technical systems what hacking is to technical systems
- What lessons are translatable?



SECTION 2



THE MEDIA AS A SECURITY ENVIRONMENT

Maybe?



COMPUTER SECURITY	MEMETIC SECURITY
SOFTWARE	MEME
HACKER	TROLL
PHISHING	BAITING
SYSTEM	PLATFORM / OUTLET
SYSADMIN	EDITOR / MODERATOR
VENDOR	PUBLISHER / OWNER
SOFTWARE DEVELOPER	MEMER
USER	AUDIENCE / LURKER
SECURITY RESEARCHER	???
PENETRATION TESTER	CRITICAL TROLL / ARTIST
	WHITE HAT TROLL?

Trolling as Attention Hacking

- Agenda Setting (from below)
- Attention is a scarce resource (attention economics)
- Legacy gatekeepers (media) compete with an emergent class of network (social media) gatekeepers to direct attention.
- Trolling as social engineering: gaining access (via gatekeepers) to the resources of a closed system (their audience)

Network Gatekeeping

- Newspaper editors and reporters
- Platform designers / vendors
- Platform algorithms
- Content moderators
- Advertisers
- Anyone with framing or curating capacity (i.e.: Users)

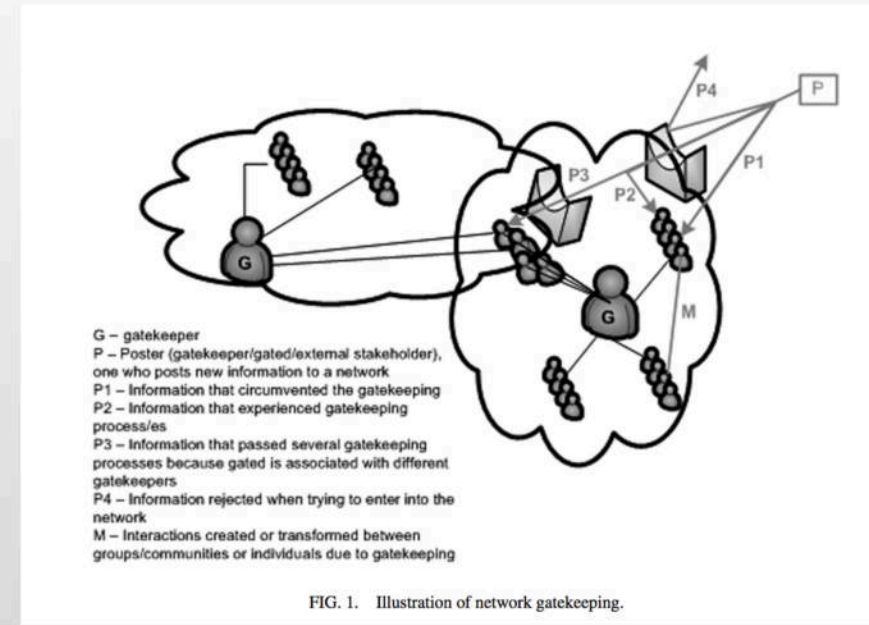


FIG. 1. Illustration of network gatekeeping.

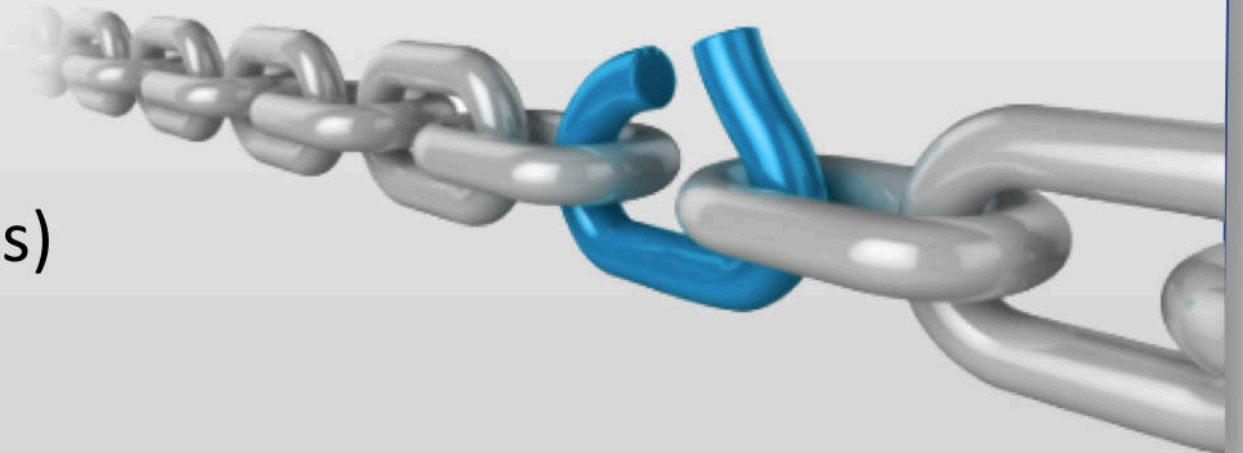
Karine Barzilai-Nahon, 2008

Trolls

- Exploiting or detouring gatekeeper vulnerabilities to affect readers / users
- Eliciting changes to gatekeeping practices
- Disclosing dynamics inherent to gatekeeping
- Posing as gatekeepers
- Capturing legacy gatekeeper resources / audiences

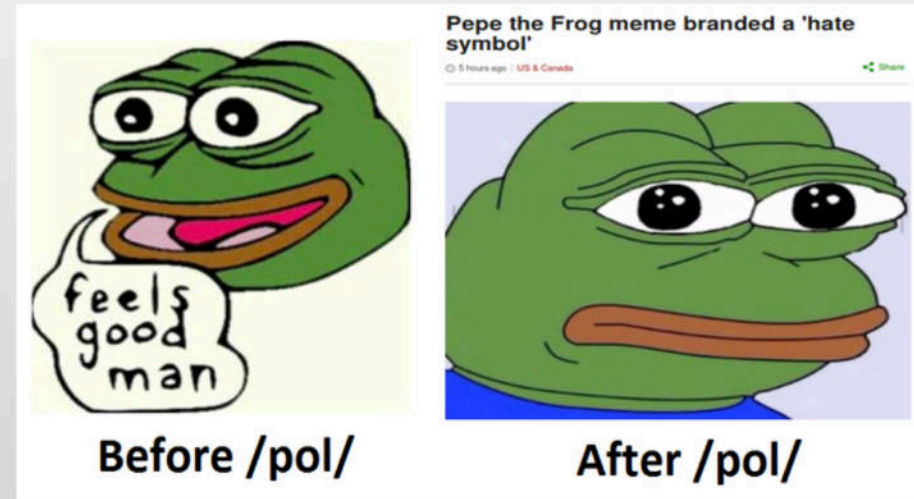
Vulnerabilities?

- Clickbait / "Bleeding Leads" / Breaking News
- Network curation
- Asymmetric cost to debunk
- Automated amplification (bots)
- Adtech
- Context collapse / Poe's Law / Anonymity

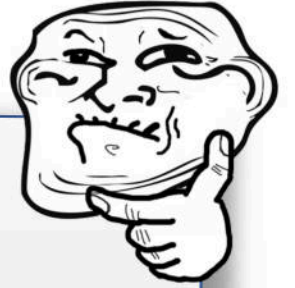


Mememes as Malware?

- Pepe as a Trojan Horse
- Vulnerabilities all the way down?
- Where does securitization stop?



Questions



- What is gatekeeper responsibility to users?
- Is this codified? How?
- Is paternalistic gatekeeping inherently authoritarian?
- Is network gatekeeping inherently democratic?
- When is gatekeeping in the public interest?

SECTION 3



POSTURES

Black hat

- Non-prescribed engagement
- Push private agenda
- Counter to target's interest



Gray hat

- Non-prescribed engagement
- Demonstrate attack surface (proof of concept)
- Trolling as revelatory moment
- Increase pressure on gatekeepers
- Troll back
- Sense of public interest?



White hat

- Align system with intent
- Disclose vulnerabilities selectively to platforms / journalists
- Disable possibility of non-prescribed engagement through research and education
- Reduce attack surface
- Create a discursive “patch” (i.e. Godwin’s Law)



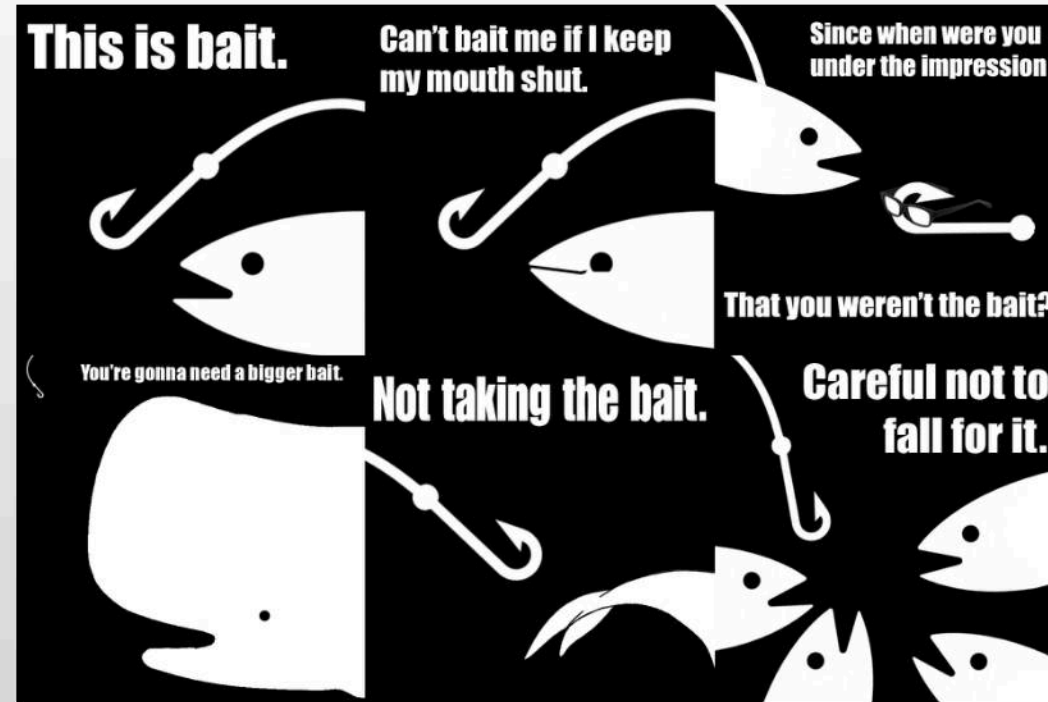
Mechanics

- Who?
- What are the incentives?
- Who is being tasked to respond?
- What is the form of disclosure?
- Whose interest is served?

And the lulz?

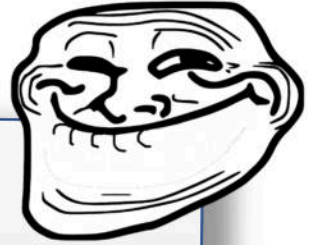
- How do "the lulz" figure in?
- What are the ethics of fun at others' expense?
- Has the adoption of trolling as a propaganda technique by states and political radicals changed the possibility of just "doing it for the lulz"? Hacking for fun?

SECTION 4



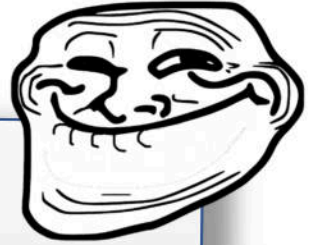
INVENTORIES

Possible Goals



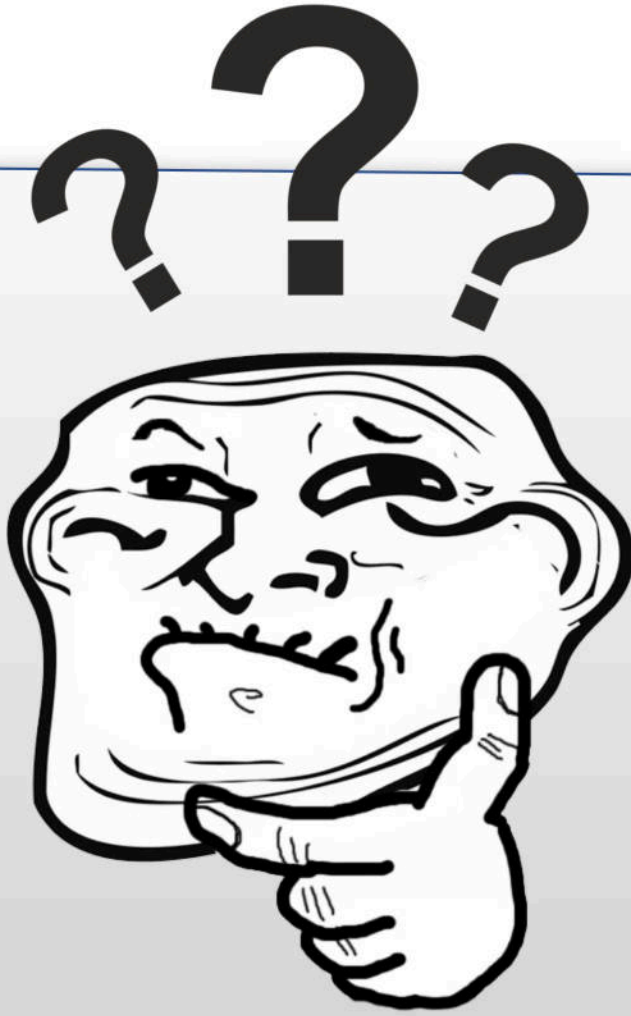
- Political Maneuvering
- Chaos / Scorched Earth
- Perception Management
- Denial of Service
- Lulz / Drama
- Agenda Setting / Priming
- Incitement
- Response seeking
- Community building
- Community governance
- Demoralization / Outrage
- Profit???

Tactics



- Source Hacking / Journobaiting
- Attentional Honeypots
- Keyword Squatting
- Capturing the Narrative
- Cognitive Denial of Service
- Brute Force Harassment
- Ironical Bait & Switch
- Gaming Databases / Algorithmic Control
- Memetic Trojan Horses
- Controlled Opposition
- Driving a Wedge
- Concern Trolling
- Brigading / Dogpiling
- Sockpuppetry
- Jiu Jitsu / Self-Victimization
- Doxing
- Context Distortion
- Deep Fakes / Photoshops

SECTION 5

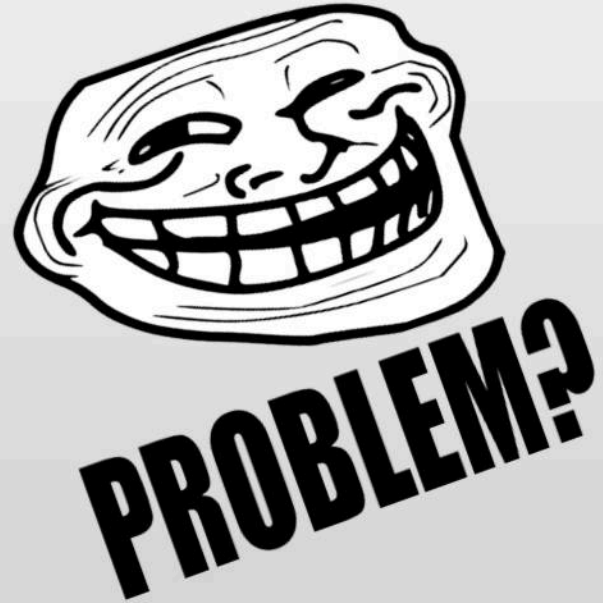


QUESTIONING

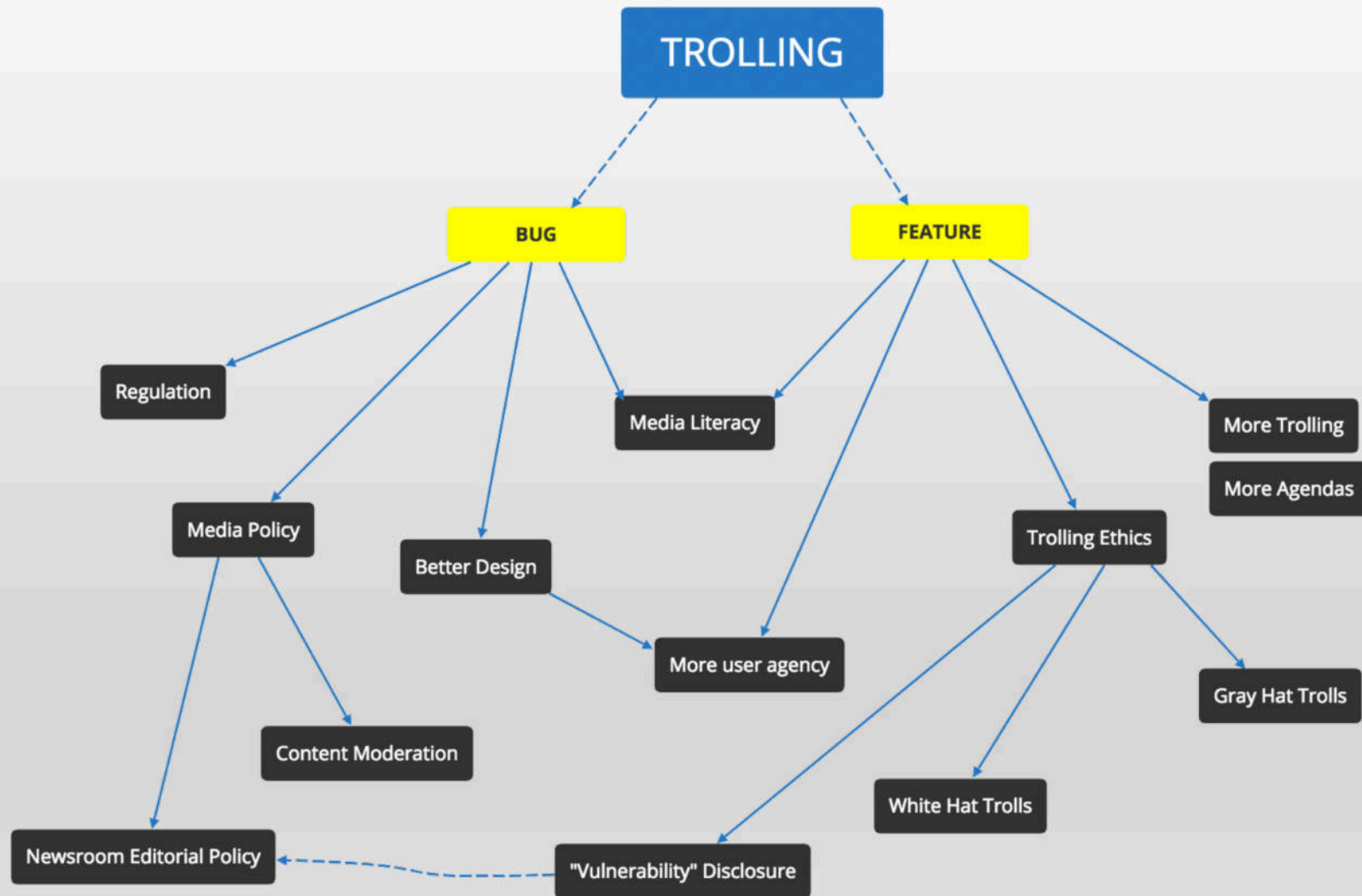
BIG QUESTION:

- **A bug or a feature?**
- Is trolling a problem?
- Or is this how networked media dynamics are supposed to work?

and WHO DECIDES?



BUG vs. FEATURE:



“Feature” Interventions:



- Do nothing
- Incentivize trolling from diverse perspectives
- A trolling arms race
- A trolling code of ethics

BUT?

“Bug” Interventions:



- Technical re-design
- Policy change
- Content moderation
- Media literacy (for users *and* gatekeepers?)
- Norms like “Don’t Feed the Trolls” / “Strategic silence”
- Regulation
- Institutionalized trust and verification

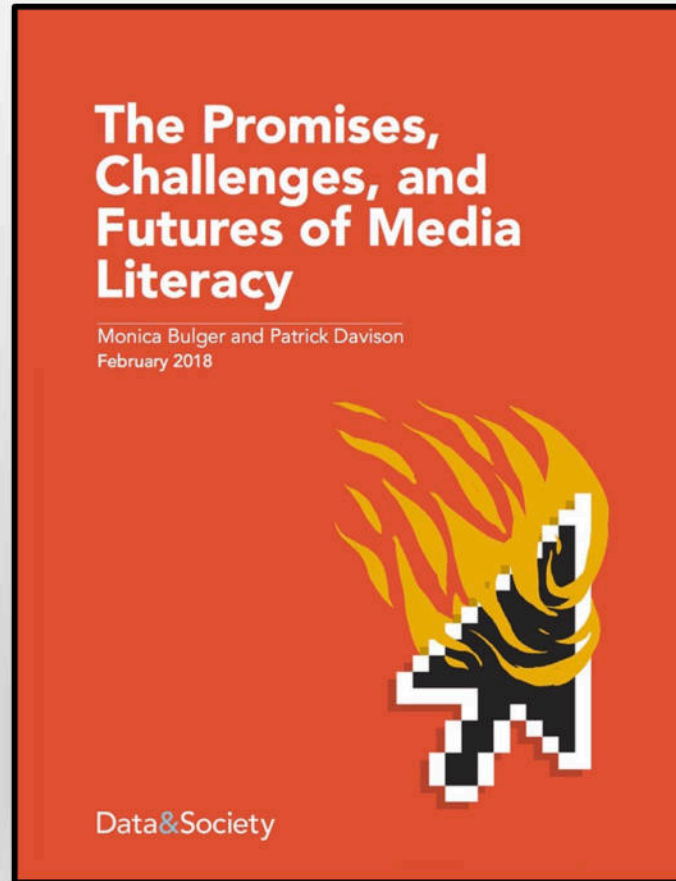
BUT?

To Consider:

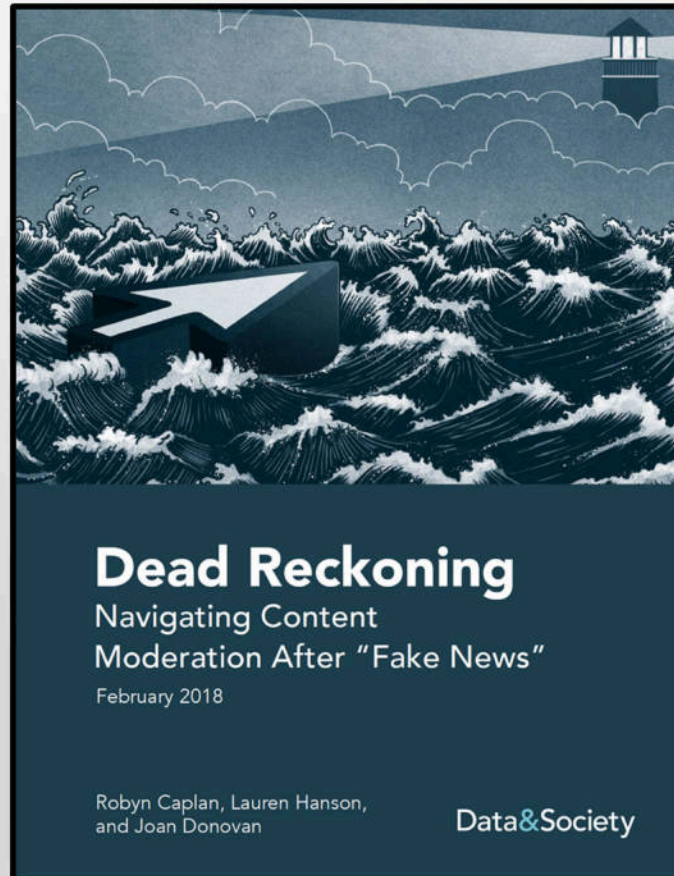


- Right to speech $\neq$ Right to amplification?
- Media Literacy vs. Attention Economics?
- Network Gatekeeping vs. Paternalism?
- What Public Interest? What Ethical system? Which Establishment?
- Who discloses, how, to whom, to what end?

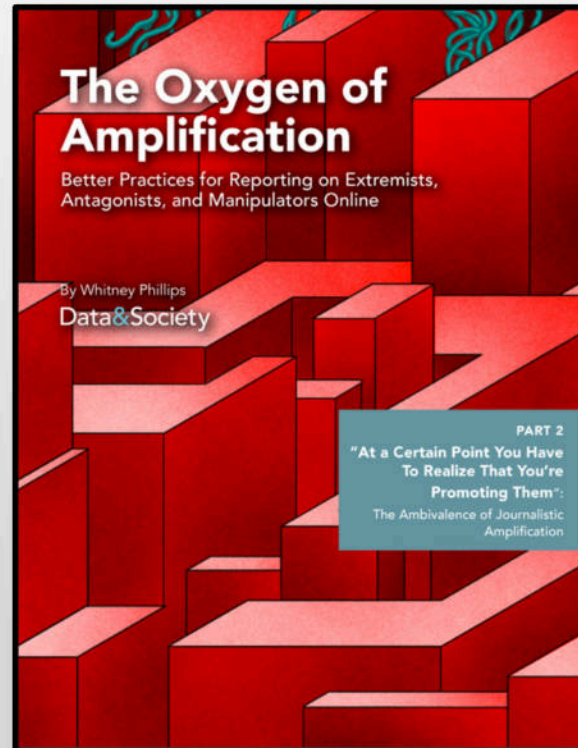
Interventions



Interventions



Interventions

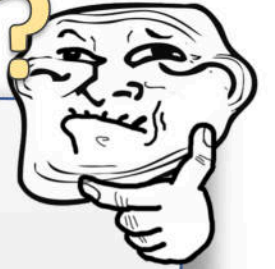


Free Speech?



- Right to free speech with your one mouth?
- Right to amplification of that speech?
- Monopolization of attention = DOS of other's
free speech?

Everyone an investigative journalist?



- Finite lifetime problem
- Can't verify/investigate every claim
- Inflammatory lies stickier and more profitable

Moderation?



- Moderation under counts
- No moderation over counts
- Do-it-yourself moderation tends to tribalism?

Regulation?



- Lessons from Computer Fraud and Abuse Act?
- Chilling Effect?
- Trolls, Platforms, Journalists?
- Negative externalities?
- Current laws in place?

Platform Redesign?



- To who's standards?
- Addressing what issues?
- Informed by red teaming "white hat trolls?"
- Informed by external pressure from "gray hat trolls?"

Disclosure?

- Proof of Concept?
- Full disclosure? Security Economics?
- Markets?
- Selective Disclosure? Security Research?
- Bounty Programs? Penetration Testing? Auditing?
- Professionalization?



More Trolls?

- White Hats, Gray Hats, Black Hats?
- More Positions, More Issues
- Politics of Spectacle
- Agonistic Politics
- Race to the Bottom?
- Norms or Codes of Ethics?

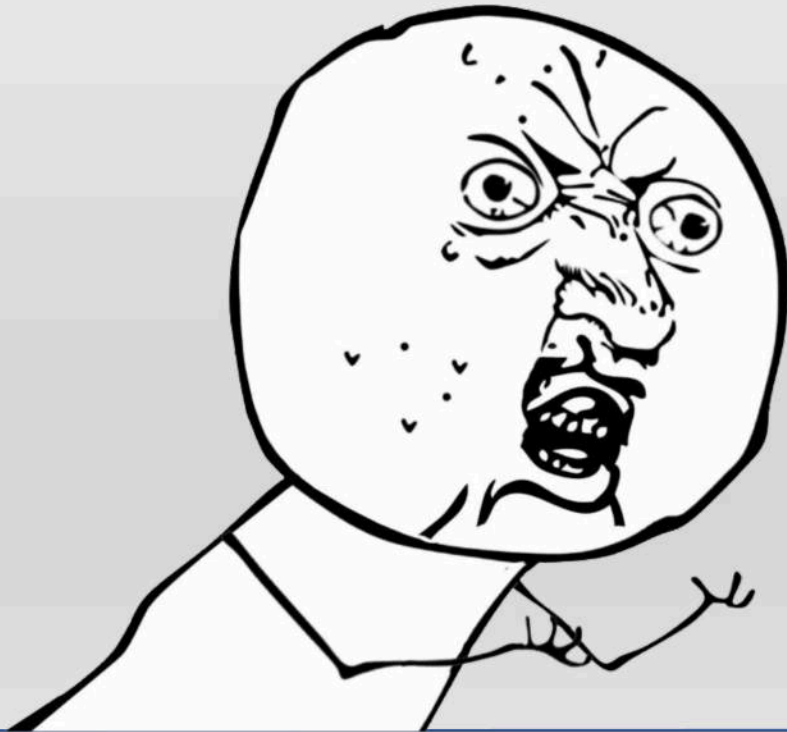


Which brand of wrong do we want?



All of the above but none too well – cracks are where the light gets through!

DISCUSSION



CONCLUSIONS

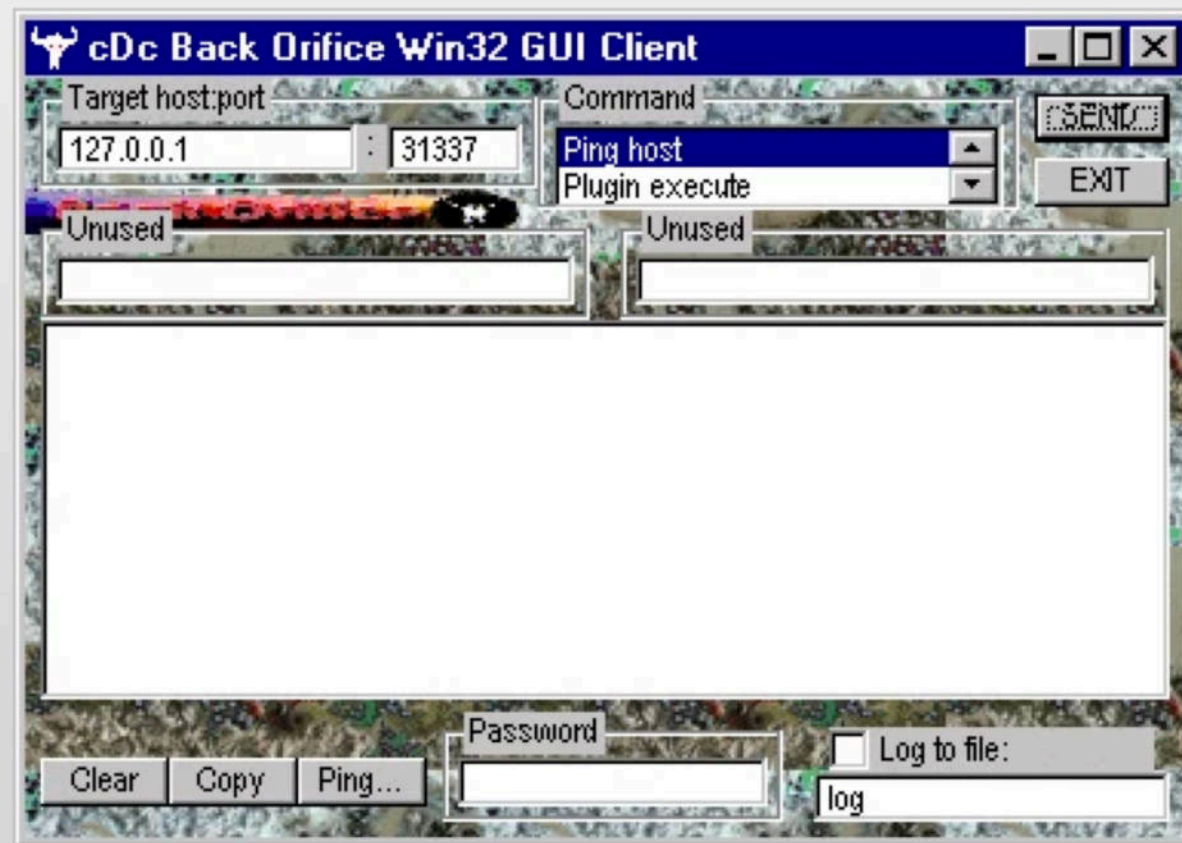


APPENDIX



CASE STUDIES

BACK ORIFICE



- Security Economics

HACKED TEAM



- Politics of Spectacle / Security Economics

PROPUBLICA INVESTIGATION



TOPICS ▼ SERIES ▼ NEWS APPS GET INVOLVED IMPACT ABOUT 🔍

✉ SIGN UP



MACHINE BIAS



Facebook Enabled Advertisers to Reach 'Jew Haters'



After being contacted by ProPublica, Facebook removed several anti-Semitic ad categories and promised to improve monitoring.



by **Julia Angwin**, **Madeleine Varner** and **Ariana Tobin**, Sept. 14, 2017, 4 p.m. EDT

- Security Economics

ANTIFA SOCKPUPPETS



- Keyword Squatting

“BLACKTIVIST”

Suggested Page

**Blacktivist**
Sponsored

Say it loud: I'm black and I'm proud!



Blacktivist
Non-Governmental Organization (NGO)
388,476 people like this.

 Like Page

**Black Lives Matter**
@blacklivesmatter1

[Home](#)
[Shop](#)
[About](#)
[Videos](#)
[Posts](#)
[Photos](#)
[Community](#)
[Create a Page](#)



 Like  Share ...

[Donate](#) [Message](#)

Shop



BLM T-Shirt (proceeds do...
\$24.00



BLM Shirt (proceeds do...
\$22.50



Black Lives Matter Mug
\$25.00

Community Organization
Always Open

Community [See All](#)
 665,193 people like this
 671,178 people follow this

About [See All](#)
 Typically replies within a day
[Contact Black Lives Matter on Messenger](#)

- Keyword Squatting

INTERNET RESEARCH AGENCY



- Scorched Earth

TAY AI



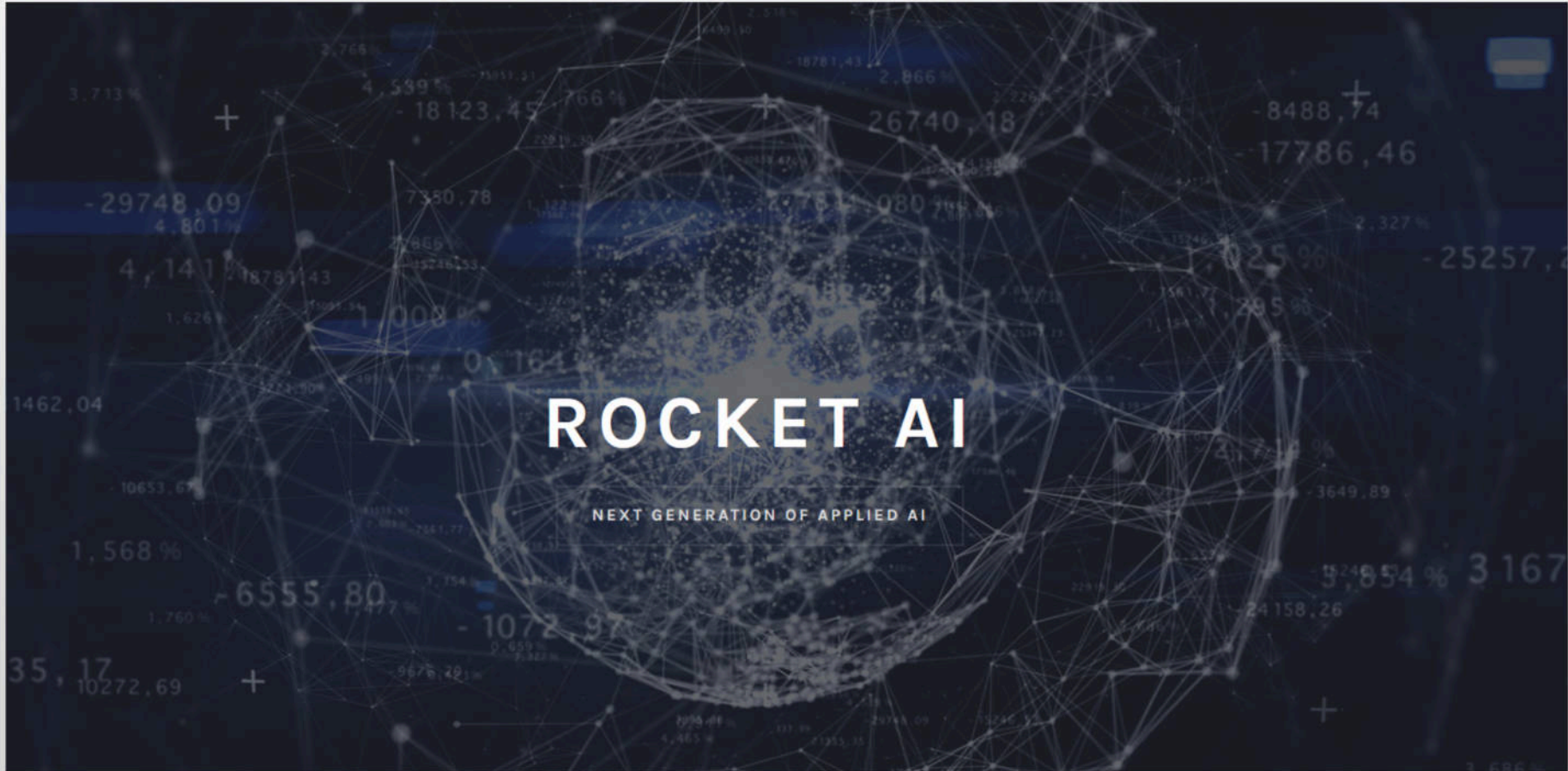
- Algorithmic Gaming

DOXING NSA GRAPHIC DESIGNER



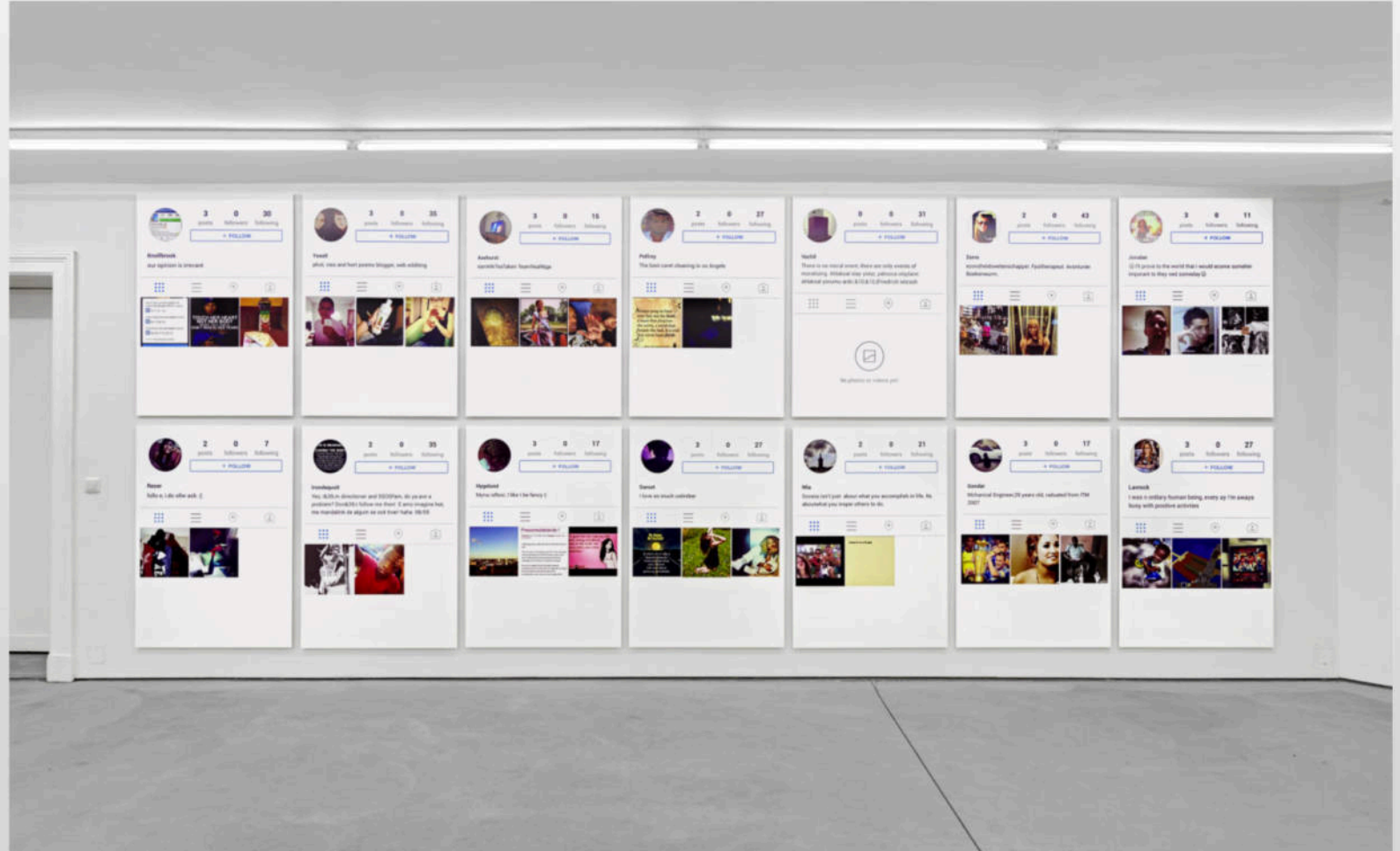
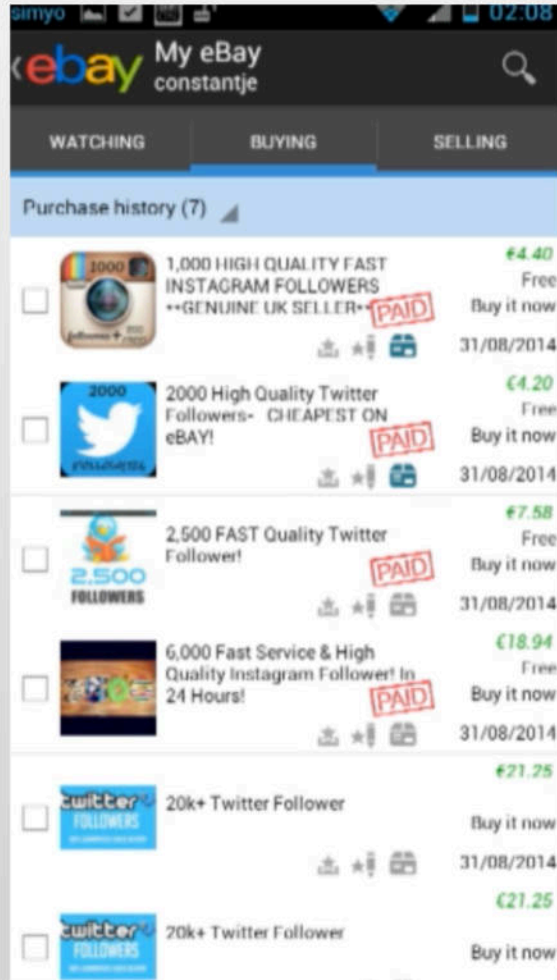
- Critical Trolling

TITS.AI and ROCKET AI



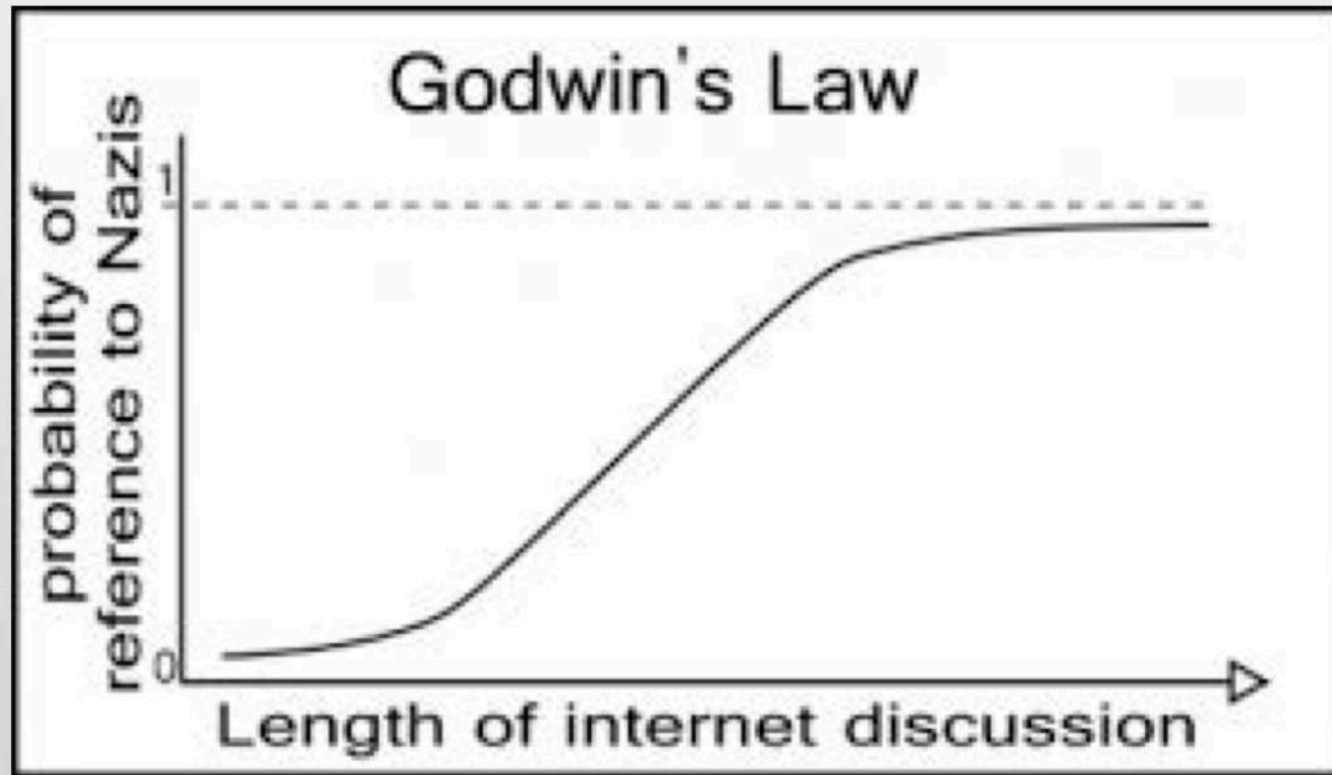
- Critical Trolling

100,000 FOLLOWERS



- Critical Trolling

GODWIN'S LAW



- Counter Meme

SAM HYDE IS THE SHOOTER



- Source Hacking

IMPOSTER BUSTER

TWEETS
17

FOLLOWERS
363

Tweets

Tweets & replies

Media



Imposter Buster @ImposterBuster · 4h

Have you encountered a racist troll impersonating a Jew, African-American, Latino or Muslim on Twitter? Send it over & I'll get on the case!

Shlomo Goldman

From Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia

Shlomo Goldman, also known as the Zerk-Bomber robot, is the name of a racist troll who impersonates a Jew on Twitter. He is known for his racist tweets and for impersonating a Jew to defame Jews.

Imposter Buster @ImposterBuster

@Rabbi_Yehudah1 FYI, this account is a racist impersonating a Jew to defame Jews.



Imposter Buster

@ImposterBuster

I'm a Twitter bot that exposes racist trolls impersonating Jews and other minorities. Created by @chandraneal and @Yair_Rosenberg.

twitter.com/Yair_Rosenberg...

Joined November 2016

 Tweet to Imposter Buster

- Counter Trolling

OVER 9000 PENISES



“Trolls?
On *my* message boards?”

It's more likely than you think.

FREE PC CHECK!

 CONTENTwatch™

- Lulz or Retroactive Proof of Concept

POOL'S CLOSED



- Lulz or Proof of Concept

PROMOTED TWEETS

**Andrew Auernheimer** @rabite
Whites need to stand up for one another and defend ourselves from violence and discrimination. Our race is dying.

Andrew Auernheimer
 Promoted



**Cassius**
@CaiusTSR



I'm sorry, what the fuck is this garbage?

8:57 PM - 3 May 2015

  33  13

- Attention Hacking

SHAQ ATTACK

[Are you Shaquille O'Neal - Want to see your dream artwork?](http://www.bocagallery.biz/shaq)
www.bocagallery.biz/shaq
Shaq saves 20%!



- Critical Trolling

MACRON "LEAKS"

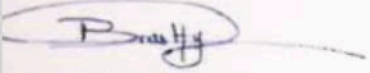
Fax			FirstCaribbean International Bank
TO:	Richard Palmer		
COMPANY:	La Providence Ltd.		
TEL:	1-869-469-2829		
FAX NO.:	1-869-469-8509		
FROM:	Brian Hydes		
TEL:	1-345-815-2252		
DATE:	11/02/15		
NO. OF PAGES:	2		
COPY:			

RE: Returned Cheque

Dear Mr. Palmer,

Please find the attached copy of the returned cheque as requested. The original was sent via mail.

Regards,



Brian Hydes
Transactional Banking Associate
International Banking Centre

CIBC FirstCaribbean
(Cayman) Limited
PO BOX 66 GT
25 Main Street
Grand Cayman, Cayman Islands

www.firstcaribbeanbank.com
Tel: (345) 949-7300
Fax: (345) 949-7179

- Cognitive Denial of Service

HBGARY



aaronbarr

<http://vocaroo.com/?media=vY7n2sXJaoPZVTHGq>
Aaron's new resumé amirite #hurrhurr

3 minutes ago via web

Spot the edit: <http://www.linkedin.com/in/tedvera> Fuck you Ted Vera, you're not getting away either! Nom nom nom, who's next? Penny? #hbgary

5 minutes ago via web

Here's my address: 1 [REDACTED]

26 minutes ago via web

Here's my social security number: [REDACTED]

29 minutes ago via web

Sup, here's rootkit.com MySQL Backup http://stfu.cc/rootkit_com_mysqlbackup_02_06_11.gz #hbgary #rootkit #anonymous

39 minutes ago via web

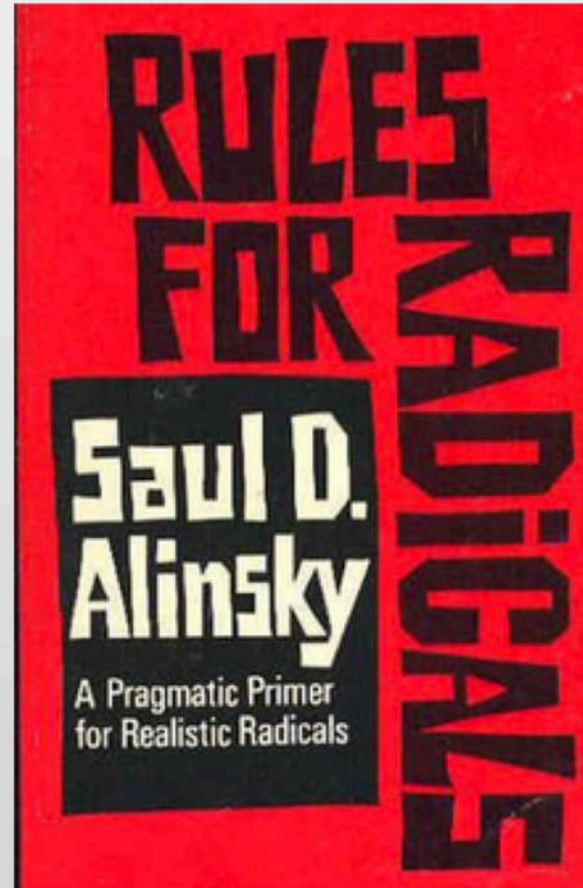
@HarikariButterK Row row fight the Feds! Anons of the world: we have your back. These corporate wankstains will never bring us down. #anon

42 minutes ago via web

Oh and here's ~50,000 HBGary emails! [http://thepiratebay.org/torrent/\[REDACTED\]](http://thepiratebay.org/torrent/[REDACTED]) #hbgary Have a good one!

- Ruin Life Campaign

SAUL ALINSKY



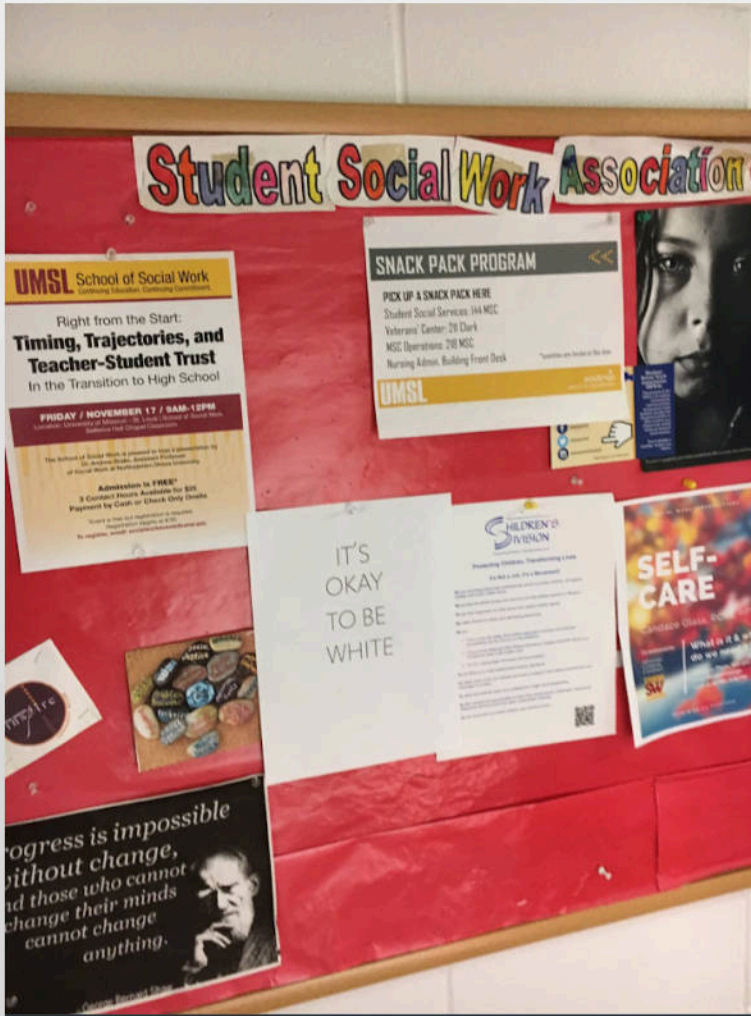
- Attention Hacking

THE DAILY STORMER



- Weaponized Irony

IOTBW POSTER CAMPAIGN



- Jiu Jitsu

REPUBLIC OF FLORIDA



158KiB, 1542x1134, Me and nick.jpg

[View Same](#) [Google](#) [iqdb](#) [SauceNAO](#) [Download](#)

Nikolas Cruz shooting Anonymous ID:NIYXoxqv Wed 14 Feb 2018 23:24:58 No.160524925 

[126 / 35]

[View](#) [Reply](#) [Original](#) [Report](#)

Quoted By: >>160525060 >>160525081 >>160525157 >>160525215 >>160525336 >>160525618 >>160525701 >>160525771 >>160526253
>>160526423 >>160526877 >>160526928 >>160528519 >>160528550 >>160528610 >>160529481 >>160529822 >>160530163
>>160530342 >>160530440 >>160530960 >>160531037 >>160531156 >>160531417 >>160532208 >>160532661 >>160533641

I've kept quiet for long enough. I've decided that its time the world know the truth about ROF.

Nikolas Cruz was a revolutionary member of the Republic of Florida, who preached twisted and dark things like terrorism and attacking innocent people.

I used to be a member of ROF, but I left because of the violent views that Nikolas and people like him were pushing. I voiced my concerns to some of the leadership of ROF, but they all supported what he said.

The Republic of Florida is terrifying and clearly they're willing to kill anyone. Nikolas was actually one of the less violent ones.

This is going to happen again if something doesn't change

- Source Hacking

SPOON SCULPTURE AT PURDUE PHARMA



- Attention Hacking

KEN M – YAHOO! TROLL

Homeless Man's Honest Deed Rewarded with \$16K Donation, and Counting

By William Browning | Yahoo! Contributor Network – Thu, Feb 21, 2013



Email



Share

9659



Tweet

733



Share

0



Print



Ken M • 8 hrs ago | [Remove](#)

he'll probly blow it all on food and shelter

1 4



Gary W • 7 hrs ago | [Report Abuse](#)

Food and shelter are the basic things for survival, what did you mean by saying that is "blowing" it? Maybe for you there are more urgent and important things—like crack?

0 1



Ken M • 6 hrs ago | [Remove](#)

how come he don't donate the money to rich folk

0 0

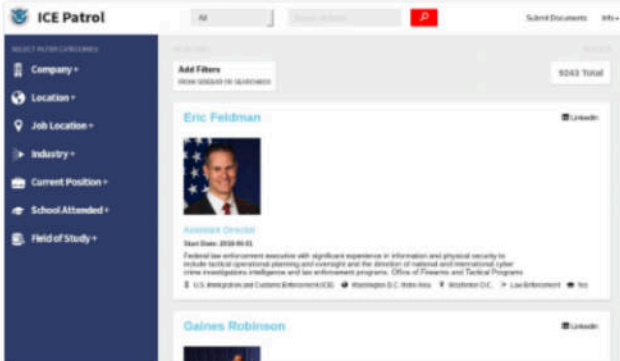
- Lulz?

ICE DATABASE

 **WikiLeaks** 
@wikileaks

Following

RELEASE: ICEPatrol is a searchable archive of US Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) employees with LinkedIn profiles. WikiLeaks is publishing this dataset in searchable format after it was censored by Github and Medium.
ice.wikileaks.org



5:59 PM - 21 Jun 2018

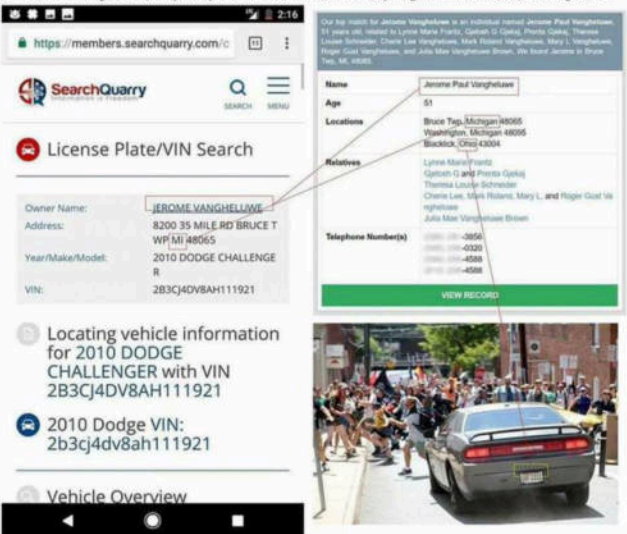
97 Retweets 110 Likes

WIKILEAKS is absolutely compromised. If you need proof, here it is. Unbelievable.

- Brute Force Provocation

CHARLOTTESVILLE DRIVER

This is Jerome Vangheluwe. He is the owner of the 2010 Dodge Challenger which crashed into 20 people at an Antifa rally in Virginia. He has lived in Michigan, Ohio, and possibly now lives in Detroit. He most likely bought this car for his son, Joel Vangheluwe.

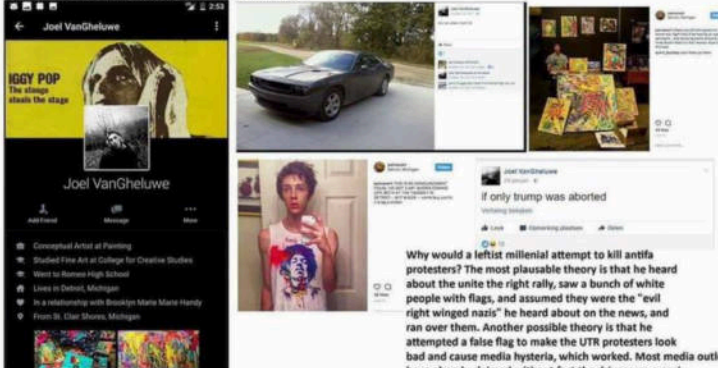


Locating vehicle information for 2010 DODGE CHALLENGER with VIN 2B3CJ4DV8AH111921

2010 Dodge VIN: 2b3cj4dv8ah111921

Vehicle Overview

This is Joel Vangheluwe, the son of Jerome. He has posted pictures of the Dodge Challenger claiming it as his 'new car'. He is an anti-Trump leftist. Why would a leftist drive their car into an antifa rally?



Why would a leftist millennial attempt to kill antifa protesters? The most plausible theory is that he heard about the unite the right rally, saw a bunch of white people with flags, and assumed they were the "evil right winged nazis" he heard about on the news, and ran over them. Another possible theory is that he attempted a false flag to make the UTR protesters look bad and cause media hysteria, which worked. Most media outlets have already claimed without fact the driver was a nazi

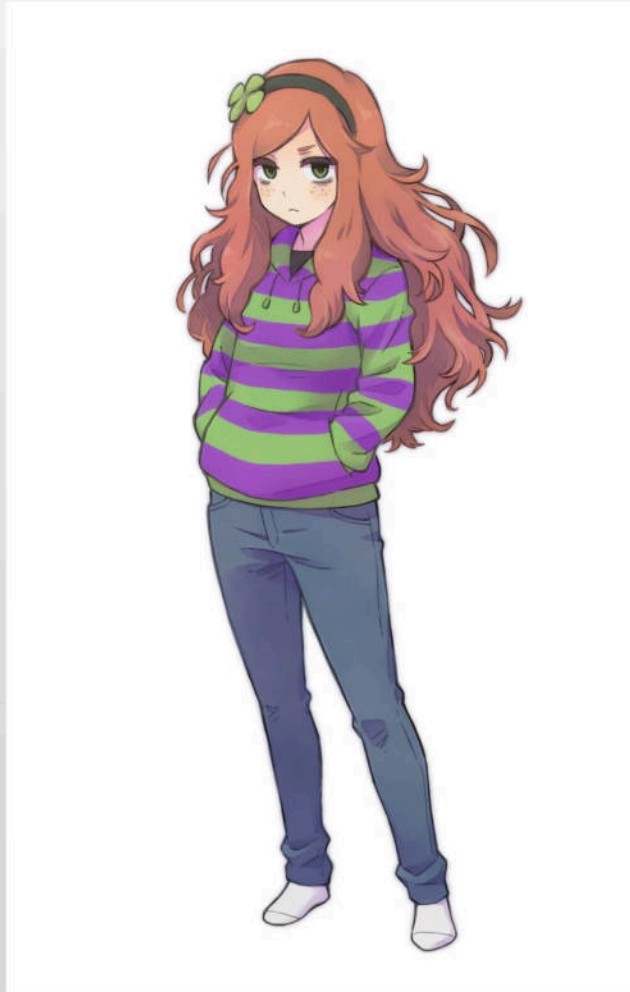
- News Spamming / Counter Framing

@YesYoureRacist



- Concern Trolling

VIVIAN JAMES



- Concern Trolling

OCCIDENTAL COLLEGE FAKE RAPE REPORTS



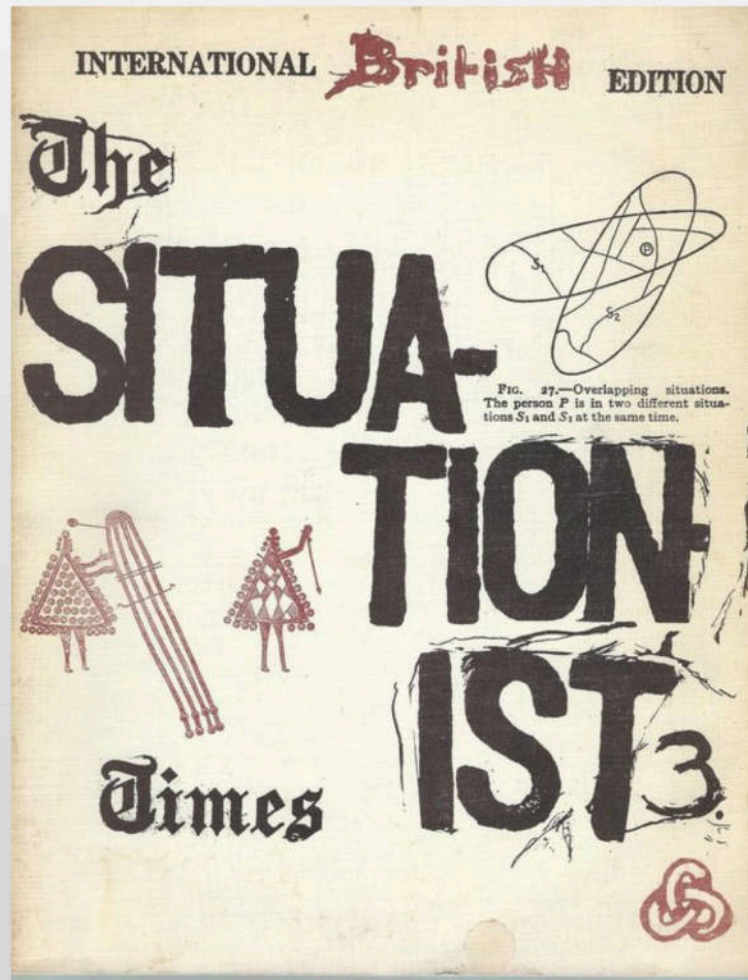
- Denial of Service / Harassment

ESTEBAN WINSMORE



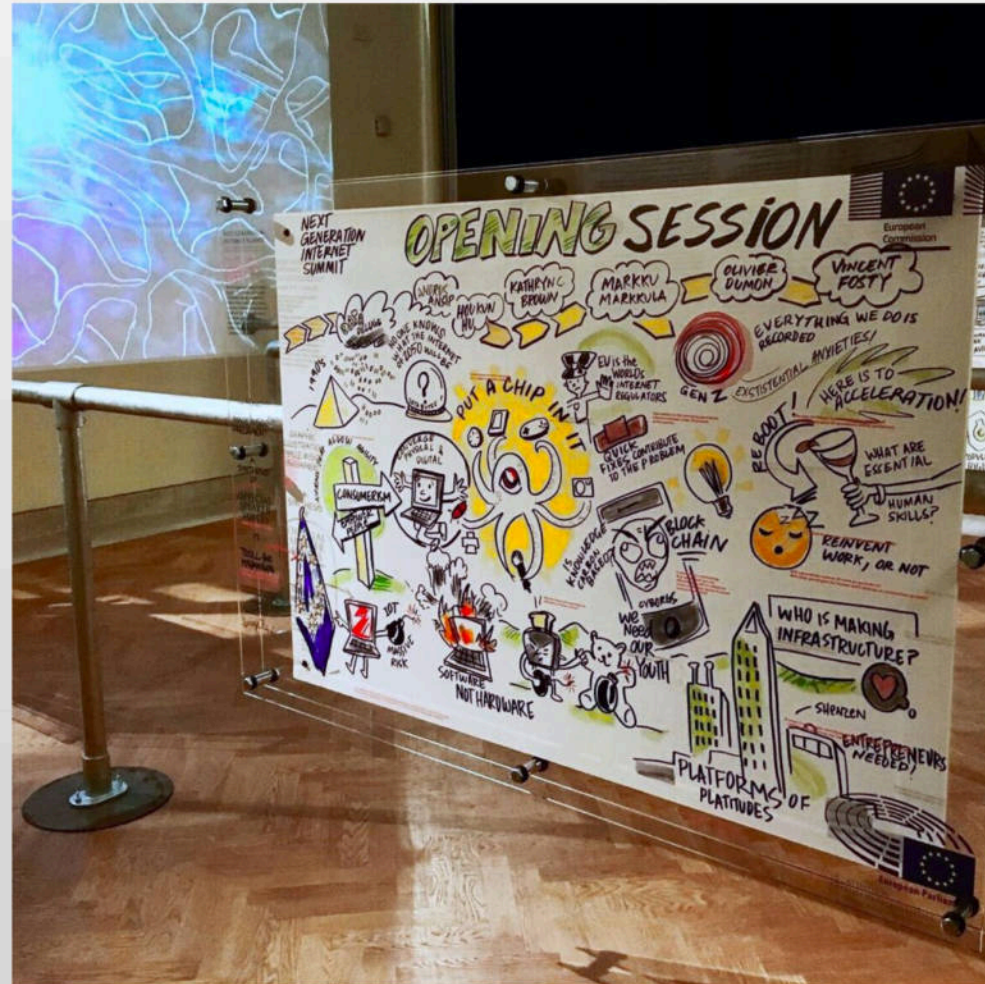
- Concern Trolling / Ethnography

LETTRISM, SITUATIONISM



- Politics of Spectacle

EUROPEAN COMMISSION



- Approved Trolling

RUSSIAN MEMES

48. During November 2016, the Conspirators used Guccifer 2.0 to “shit-post” over 16,000 times online. The posts contained both domestic and foreign memes, as well as 514 separate incidences of a post consisting solely of “lol” or “lmao.”

- a. On or about November 18, 2016, the Conspirators created a meme known as “Borgar,” which was then combined with existing viral media to infiltrate the international meme community.
- b. The Conspirators did, on or about November 28, 2016, create the meme “Soup time,” in which a frog steals money from his mother, diverting the funds to instead purchase



drewtoothpaste
@drewtoothpaste



What the FUCK to the Russian-meme details of this FBI indictment

12:40 PM - Jul 13, 2018

♡ 5,366 💬 1,649 people are talking about this



mieke eoyang ✓ @MiekeEoyang · 13 Jul



So, @drewtoothpaste, you want to own up to

- a) a mistake
 - b) a joke
 - c) being complicit in a disinformation campaign?
- twitter.com/gabrielmalor/s...



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@drewtoothpaste

i'm a humor writer, not a news source. don't get mad at me if you don't know who i am or don't bother to read my bio

1:59 PM - Jul 13, 2018

♡ 985 💬 61 people are talking about this



- Humor as Incidental Troll